



The Importance of Postsecondary Education for Individuals With Intellectual Disability

The education, employment, and community outcomes for individuals with intellectual disability have historically been bleak in our country. Many people with intellectual disability wind up living in poverty, working subminimum-wage jobs in segregated “sheltered workshops,” or living at home with aging parents and little community engagement.

This situation is starting to improve as individuals with intellectual disability are being included with their nondisabled peers in postsecondary education. As of July 2023, there are over 320 of these programs across the country. As colleges and universities open their doors to students with intellectual disability, these individuals are experiencing substantially better outcomes in employment, social engagement, and community living (Butler, Sheppard-Jones, Whaley, Harrison, & Osness, 2016; Grigal, Hart, Papay, Wu, Lazo, Smith, & Domin, 2021; Moore & Schelling, 2015; Sannicandro, 2019).

WHAT DOES POSTSECONDARY EDUCATION CHANGE FOR PEOPLE WITH INTELLECTUAL DISABILITY?

- » **Higher wages:** Youth with intellectual disability who participated in postsecondary education and vocational rehabilitation services (VR) were more than twice as likely to exit with paid jobs, earned \$406 per month more on average, and required \$77 less per month in supplemental social security (SSI) benefits than their counterparts without postsecondary education (Sannicandro, 2019).
- » **Meaningful work experience:** In 2021–2022, 95% of students at model transition programs for students with intellectual disability (TPSIDs)* participated in paid employment or career development activities (work-based learning, career awareness and exploration, or job seeking)
 - 38% of students had a paid job while enrolled. Of those, 95% were working in competitive, integrated employment at or above minimum wage.
 - 50% of students who were employed had never held a paid job before entering the program.

» **Continued employment after college:** Data from 2021-22 show:

- 63% of students who completed TPSID programs in 2011-12 through 2021-22 had a paid job 1 year after exit
- 59% of students who completed TPSID programs in 2021-22 were working in a paid job at exit or within the first 90 days after exiting.
- 76% of students either had a paid job (at exit or within 90 days), were participating in unpaid career development activities, or were doing a combination of these activities upon completion.

» **Living in inclusive settings:** In 2021-2022:

- 70% of TPSID programs at residential campuses (i.e., not commuter schools) offered access to housing for students with intellectual disability.
- 60% of ALL students who enrolled in a TPSID lived in housing associated with the college or university.

HOW DO WE KNOW THESE PROGRAMS ARE GROWING AND SUSTAINABLE?

» **Program growth:** Colleges and universities in 34 states have received TPSID grants (2010–2025). There are over 320 postsecondary education programs for students with intellectual disability in 49 states, and the number is growing.

» **Student retention:** In 2021-2022, the retention rate (i.e., percentage of previous first-year students returning to college for a second year) for TPSID programs was 90%. As compared to 75% for first-time, full-time, degree/certificate-seeking undergraduate students who enrolled in postsecondary institutions in Fall 2021, (National Center for Education Statistics, 2021)”

» **Fund matching:** TPSID projects are required to match 25% of the funds they receive from the Department of Education thus extending the reach of the federal dollars.

» **Cross-agency support:** In 2021-2022, 84% of TPSIDs received some financial support from external sources, such as state VR and state intellectual and developmental disability agencies, including for student tuition further leveraging the federal dollars.

WHAT ARE CURRENT OUTCOMES FOR INDIVIDUALS WITH INTELLECTUAL DISABILITY?

- » **Lack of competitive employment:** The number of adults with intellectual disability in integrated employment has shown only modest growth since 1990 (Winsor et al., 2021). In 2018-2019, 19% of adults with developmental disabilities in the general population had a paid job in the community (National Core Indicators, 2019).
- » **Facility-based work:** In FY2018, 78.9% of people with intellectual disability were being served in facility-based and non-work settings (Winsor et al., 2021).
- » **Poor transition outcomes:** In 2014, the employment rate for transition-age individuals with cognitive disability (ages 16-21) was 20%, or less than half the employment rate for same-age people without disabilities (Winsor et al., 2021).

SOURCES

- Butler, L. N., Sheppard-Jones, K., Whaley, B., Harrison, B., & Osness, M. (2016). Does participation in higher education make a difference in life outcomes for students with intellectual disability? *Journal of Vocational Rehabilitation*, 44, 295-298. doi:10.3233/JVR-160804
- Grigal, M., Hart, D., Papay, C., Bukaty, C., Choiseul-Praslin, B., Lazo, R. (2023). Annual Report of the Cohort 3, TPSID Model Demonstration Projects (Year 2, 2019-2022). Boston, MA: University of Massachusetts Boston, Institute for Community Inclusion.
- Moore, E. J., & Schelling, A. (2015). Postsecondary inclusion for individuals with an intellectual disability and its effects on employment. *Journal of Intellectual Disabilities*, 19, 130-48. doi: 10.1177/1744629514564448.
- Sannicandro, T. (2019). The effect of postsecondary education on employment, income, and SSI for people with intellectual disabilities. *Think College Fast Facts*, Issue No. 24. Boston, MA: University of Massachusetts Boston, Institute for Community Inclusion.
- Winsor, J., Timmons, J., Butterworth, J., Migliore, A., Domin, D., Zalewska, A., & Shepard, J. (2021). *StateData: The National Report on Employment Services and Outcomes Through 2018*. Boston, MA: Institute for Community Inclusion.

***TPSIDs:** The Higher Education Opportunity Act created the Transition and Postsecondary Programs for Students with Intellectual Disabilities, or TPSIDs. These model demonstration programs develop inclusive higher education options for people with intellectual disability. The program was first implemented by the Office of Postsecondary Education in 2010, through the awarding of five-year grants to 27 institutes of higher education (IHEs). The five-year TPSID grants were awarded again in 2015 to a second cohort of 25 IHEs, and in 2020 to a third cohort of 19 IHEs. These IHEs are tasked with creating, expanding, or enhancing high-quality, inclusive higher education experiences to support positive outcomes for individuals with intellectual disability.